

How can Hotels of Every Size Create the Right Technology Roadmap



A guide for small chains, independent and boutique hotels to build a level-playing field using technology

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The Journey

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Why do Hotels Need a Roadmap?

In the last decade, easy access to high-speed internet, the penetration of smartphones and the participation of companies such as Google and other startups in creating omni channel experiences in our day-to-day lives have created a mismatch between guest expectations and what hotels can offer their guests today.

As hospitality executives finally move on from dealing with one of the biggest crises faced by the industry in the last century, they realize that their target audience has moved further ahead in embracing technology. Hotels of yesterday, stood for being exclusive, and create unique experiences that guests paid a premium for, however, in today's world the guests demand an experience tailored to their preferences, and are willing to pay extra.

While guests expect more, hotels struggle to add staff, upgrade technology, and optimize costs to invest in creating better experiences as they enter 2024 realizing that instead of exclusivity, they need to build an experience that can easily tether to the guest's existing ecosystem making them at ease instantly.

To connect with this guest ecosystem, we brought together the entire hospitality ecosystem comprising of hospitality, travel-technology, and consumer internet companies to help build the roadmap to determine how we will match the guest expectation and what challenges lie ahead in improving brand loyalty and increasing profitability.

Large hotel chains have had the benefit of having dedicated technology budgets, center of excellences and an advantage over smaller chains and independent hotels when it comes to engaging potential guests. Through this document, RateGain and Singapore Institute of Technology, together with IDEaS and Google, brought together hospitality leaders to build a guide that hotels can use at each step of the customer journey.

Why does Guest Experience Matter More in Hospitality?

The hospitality sector is fundamentally a service industry. Unlike manufactured products, services are intangible; they cannot be touched, previewed, or stored.

While traditional hotels have always believed that the effectiveness of a hotel's services is contingent upon the customer's experience during its delivery, in the digital age the expectation of the service is built from the zero moment of truth, when the guest interacts with the brand during the dreaming stage and at each subsequent stage, increases its expectation of the final experience.

Each phase of this journey presents a distinct opportunity for hoteliers to make an indelible impact on their guests, thereby instigating a desire to embark upon the journey once more. Comprehending the needs of customers at every stage of their experience is therefore paramount for hoteliers to effectively compete in the digital age. However, as guest expectations perpetually shift and technology assumes a more prominent role, the industry is confronted with a plethora of challenges in effectively garnering repeat business.

Not meeting expectations at any stage, impacts the guest perception of service and impacts not only retention but new business as well as TripAdvisor shared in their research that the intensity of negative experiences since the pandemic has been increasing, making it difficult for hotels to manage its reputation.



How does the Guest Journey Look Like in Hospitality?

The guest journey in the digital age serves as an all-encompassing framework that delineates the full lifecycle of a guest's engagement with a hotel brand, product, or service. It encapsulates not merely the literal act of traveling to and from the hotel, but also symbolizes the diverse stages and touchpoints

encountered by individuals as they transition from potential customers, to making a purchase decision, experiencing the service, and potentially, evolving into loyal, repeat patrons. This journey can be compartmentalized into four distinct phases, typically comprising:

01 Dreaming



Hotel brands are increasingly focusing on engaging potential guests prior to travel, setting expectations and offering a preview of the destination experience to gain a competitive edge.

02 Planning and Consideration



This is when the traveller starts thinking of dates, places, budget and activities and visits multiple websites across multiple weeks to make a plan.

03 Booking



Guests decide on the best offer and hotel based on expectations. They prefer easy-to-understand information from hotels and booking sites for informed decisions.

04 Experience and Retention



Where ongoing interactions (including the stay itself) and the customers' satisfaction, plays a pivotal role in potentially starting the journey again, thereby driving repeat business.

The mindset change critical for hospitality leaders is to think of the guest journey across the four phases instead of just the experience phase, and then revisiting their marketing, sales, and customer service playbooks and technology stacks to align with customer expectations at each juncture, ultimately culminating in heightened customer satisfaction, loyalty, and overall business success.

The Impact of Creating a Technology Roadmap Based on the Guest Journey

The customer journey's integral importance is unequivocally supported by compelling statistics. Hanover Research's 2022 report on customer journey mapping shows that 79% of companies acknowledge the pivotal role of journey mapping in fostering a customer-centric orientation.

According to eMarketer's 2023 report, the travel sector will experience the fastest growth rate in digital ad spending relative to all other industries, with a projected increase of 14.3% by the end of 2023. In fact, from the moment a guest contemplates a trip until their return home, technology is intricately woven into their experience, impacting each stage of the customer journey.

01 Dreaming



In this initial phase, digital marketing technologies such as targeted advertising, social media platforms, chatbot and other AI-driven recommendation engines are employed to capture customer attention and stimulate interest.

02 Planning and Consideration



This second phase leverages websites, mobile apps, and e-commerce platforms to provide customers with user-friendly interfaces for research and comparison. According to Google's research 93% of all travel searches now involve a smartphone making it imperative for hotels to consider how to be visible across different devices and platforms.

03 Booking



This phase relies on secure payment gateways, booking systems, and platforms for customer trust and convenience. Chatbots enhance real-time assistance, a trend set to grow, with the hotel reservation software market projected to expand.

04 Experience and Retention



In the final phase, technology aids in gathering feedback, monitoring satisfaction, and personalizing interactions. Email marketing, loyalty programs, and CRM systems enhance customer retention and engagement, supported by consumer preference for personalized recommendations.

Understanding and harnessing these technological advancements is essential to effectively navigate the rapidly evolving digital marketplace confidently and innovatively. This will ensure that hoteliers consistently exceed the expectations of their guests at all four stages of the customer journey.

How to Catch Travelers Dreaming?

Reduce Response Time, Target Intent Pro-actively

The dreaming phase today is one of the most complicated considering it is difficult to track when actually potential travelers want to book their travel. With limited marketing budgets and lack of the right talent, smaller hotels struggle to understand how to track travelers during this phase of the journey.

Today, there are hundreds of websites and multiple social media platforms, which have thousands of accounts that might talk about travel to your destination. It is critical to understand through simple guest feedback collection how did they hear about your property and basis that invest your time and resources behind that source to influence more bookings from that channel.

Hotels also need to check their booking data for the past few years to analyze what trends are they witnessing in terms of source markets, while this is not the best strategy, however in the absence of a sophisticated travel-intent tracking software, this is the best way to track which markets they need to target on social media.

It is also critical to ear-mark some minimum funds to target keywords, source markets as well as collaborate with micro-influencers to drive more traffic towards your website as travelers enter the planning phase



The Dreaming Phase

Problems

Inability to Map Intent:

The evolving nature of travelers' interests and intents presents a significant challenge during the Dreaming Phase. For small chains it is difficult to know where to start tracking these

Lack of Awareness:

Smaller brand hotels with limited facilities and smaller portfolios often struggle to gain appeal, potentially limiting their audience reach.

Causes

Data Overload:

The accumulation of data over time from various platforms leads to information overload, making it difficult to extract actionable insights.

Manpower and Skillset Constraints:

Limited budgets and resources result in a shortage of skilled personnel to effectively manage and analyze the data.

What can Hoteliers do?

Invest in Data collection and analysis:

If you don't have a set-up and want to start somewhere, look at hiring or sharing a data analyst with another team, to analyze search trends for your destination, countries that are visiting your website, and the last 24-month bookings from OTAs to get a sense of which market to target. Get a free tool like Flourish or Looker to pull data and see trends.

If you have a setup then try to prioritize which data sources help in making better decisions, try to use basic digital marketing tools to track your competitor websites and see which keywords, pages or countries are they getting traffic from

Micro-Influencers:

Identify micro-communities with similar interests among potential guests. Influencers from key source markets are a good way to tie up and do not impact your marketing budget a lot.

Use Free AI tools:

There are abundance of AI tools with or without a small subscription fee that can help in analyzing guest feedback received over the last three months and guide your social media team to understand why guests love your hotels.

These easy-to-use tools can save hours of analysis and help connect with your guests.

What to Consider During Planning?

Building Trust and Transparency at Every Channel

In the consideration phase the challenges become more complex with integrating technology, and organizational resistance to technological change. Specifically, these challenges stem from various factors, including the diverse technological landscapes of major markets like the USA and China, necessitating distinct content and strategies to target these markets effectively. Hoteliers often grapple with budget constraints when introducing new technology, and the intricacies of the technology landscape demand additional resources and knowledge for seamless integration. Resistance to change within organizations, particularly from the higher-ups and entrenched corporate structures, can further impede the adoption of innovative practices.

Some easy to implement software requiring fewer integrations are AI powered chatbots, that can help in reducing the amount of effort your front office invests in answering queries for guests considering to book the hotel, as well as becomes a channel to market promotions and offers to attract guests during the consideration phase.

Additionally, user-generated content (UGC) is a cornerstone in building trust and influencing decisions during this stage. Hoteliers can employ several strategies to harness UGC effectively. Encouraging guests to share their experiences across various platforms, offering rewards for contributions, and responding promptly to reviews are initial steps. Curating and featuring UGC that highlights the hotel's strengths, such as guest photos and positive testimonials, is also valuable. Moreover, leveraging authentic advocates and brand influencers can further help

in spreading positive word-of-mouth that is more trusted. By seamlessly incorporating UGC into the Planning and Consideration Phase, hoteliers can engage potential guests and positively influence their decisions.

Last but not the least, is looking at auditing content across all channels. Visual and descriptive content are becoming critical as buyers want to know a lot more information about the place of stay before finalizing their decision. Hotels cannot afford to not update their website, OTA or any other search destinations with old content as the disparity in content will lead to believe that the hotel is not giving a true picture.

In summary, the Planning & Consideration Phase is a critical juncture where travelers make pivotal choices. The industry's readiness to adapt and streamline technology is paramount in navigating the complexities of market dynamics and technology integration. These insights are critical when moving into the Booking Phase, where issues like transparency, personalization, and payment options, further empower travelers in their journey.



The Planning & Consideration Phase

Problems

Lack of Tools to Monitor All Channels for Competitive

Intelligence: Giving the right offer across all devices and touchpoints is becoming more critical as travelers use multiple websites to compare prices.

Lack of Large Marketing Budgets: Smaller brand hotels with limited facilities and smaller portfolios often struggle to gain appeal, potentially limiting their audience reach.

Causes

Behavior of Different Markets (China vs. USA):

Diverse technological platforms in major markets like the USA and China necessitate separate content and strategies to target these distinct markets.

Technology Limitation:

Despite promising innovations, technology, particularly in fields like AI, is still in its early stages.

Corporate Structure Limitations:

Resistance to change from higher-ups and entrenched corporate structures can impede the integration of new technology and approaches.

What can Hoteliers do?

Invest in Data collection and analysis:

Chabots:

Deploy an easy to setup and update chatbot that can manage simple queries on your website to help guests get an understanding of everything that you have to offer.

Rely on User Generated Content:

Post on social media, and review sites about the good experience your users have had as all potential travelers will look at these channels.

Invest in Tracking Parity:

Implement a strategy to ensure that you are monitoring parity across your website as well as all major OTAs, to ensure the traveler sees the same rate everywhere

Use AI to Audit Hotel Content:

Use AI or manually audit outdated content on various channels, ensuring accurate and up-to-date representations of the property. For instance, old images of hotels on search, website or OTAs can deter travelers from considering the property.

Improving Conversions at the Booking Stage

Optimize for Conversion and Ease of Use

This phase marks a pivotal transition from intention to commitment in the customer journey. The challenges put forward by the participants in this group include transparency issues, limited payment options, personalization gaps, and concerns about price parity. These challenges trace back to factors such as disjointed systems, resistance to change, and budget constraints. Innovative solutions were proposed by the participants, such as chatbot integration, partnerships with travel providers, expanded payment choices, and unified pricing systems. The Booking Phase therefore necessitates transparency, personalization, and convenience to be effective.

To enhance the booking experience, hoteliers must therefore address common guest friction points. Streamlining complex booking forms and providing progress trackers could simplify the process. Transparency is key, necessitating clear displays of policies and pricing. With mobile bookings on the rise, optimizing the mobile experience is crucial. Moreover, offering multiple payment options and responsive guest support can swiftly resolve issues.

Additionally, real-time data proves invaluable for hoteliers during the Booking Phase. By analyzing demand, availability, and market trends, dynamic pricing adjusts rates based on occupancy and timing. Special promotions can be triggered instantly, encouraging immediate bookings during slower periods. In other words, data-driven strategies maximize revenue, while offering competitive rates and enticing deals.

In conclusion, the Booking Phase emphasizes transparency, personalization, and diverse payment options as industry game-changers. Tackling these challenges and adopting innovative solutions is essential. These insights lay the foundation for the next and final Experience & Retention Phase, where leveraging guest experiences for retention and shaping the future of hospitality experience management becomes vital to generating repeat business and loyalty.



The Booking Phase

Problems

Lack of Payment Options (Alipay / Alternative Payment Options):

Limited payment methods, typically restricted to Mastercard and VISA, can hinder bookings, especially in markets where alternative payment options like Alipay are prevalent.

Lack of Personalization: Personalization in the booking experience is often lacking, which can impact customer satisfaction and conversion rates.

Streamline Digital Marketing: The challenge lies in optimizing digital marketing efforts to effectively convert inquiries into bookings.

Price Parity (from a consumer perspective): Consumers expect consistency in prices across different platforms, necessitating a consolidated pricing system.

Lack of Experiential Merchandising: The ability to effectively showcase and sell unique experiences as part of the booking process is often limited.

Causes

Lack of Integrated Systems:

The absence of integrated systems and technologies can contribute to transparency issues and hinder seamless bookings.

Lack of Personalization:

Guests are unable to get a sense of customization, and attention they would get on the property on the hotel website, making them abandon the booking

What can Hoteliers do?

Invest in Data collection and analysis:

Integrate Internal Systems to Relevant Partners:

Collaborate with partners and other travel partners to ensure that the buyer is able to come to the booking confirmation page with minimum number of clicks.

Expand Payment Options:

To cater to diverse markets, expand payment options beyond traditional credit cards. Integrate popular alternative payment methods like to accommodate the preferences of a broader customer base.

Enhance Personalization:

Change your website basis the visitor's source market that can be tracked by IP tracking to change language, offerings and special offers curated for the relevant source market.

Experiential Merchandising:

Improve the presentation and promotion of experiential offerings during the booking process, making it easier for customers to add unique experiences to their reservations.

The Right Experience to Drive Retention

Capture Preferences and Accelerate Service Fulfilment

This stage sees the underutilization of collected data, guest recognition issues, and the absence of comprehensive solutions. These challenges stem from factors such as data underutilization, management mindsets, and limited hotel partnerships.

Innovative recommendations to address these challenges include mindset shifts, Customer Relationship Management (CRM) technology adoption, gaining management support, listing diverse experiences on brand websites, and forming partnerships with tour operators.

These findings emphasize the critical role of effectively harnessing data, enhancing guest recognition, and creating holistic experiences to drive loyalty and retention in the dynamic hospitality industry.

Effective use of guest stay data is essential for crafting personalized messaging including future offers, promotions, and communications tailored to individual preferences and behaviors. Hoteliers could employ CRM systems to collect and analyze guest data, including preferences, behaviors, and feedback.

By maintaining comprehensive guest profiles that detail room preferences, dining choices, and leisure activities, hoteliers can create personalized offers and recommendations. Personalized emails, targeted promotions, and in-app notifications could also engage guests with offers and experiences aligned with their past interactions, fostering recognition and personalization.

Importantly, building attractive and compelling loyalty programs is pivotal for encouraging guests to engage in repeat business. These programs should offer tiered rewards, where frequent stays result in progressively enhanced benefits, such as room upgrades, exclusive access, or discounts. Transparency and simplicity in earning and redeeming points were suggested by the as being fundamental. Moreover, offering unique/exclusive experiences or perks, such as early check-in, late check-out, or access to exclusive events, can differentiate a loyalty program and provide additional value to returning guests. Additionally, effective communication, clarifying program benefits and rewards, is crucial for driving guest engagement and retention.

Moreover, technology facilitates the creation of multiple touchpoints during a guest's stay, significantly elevating the overall experience at this stage of the customer journey. Mobile applications can serve as digital concierges, empowering guests to request services, make reservations, or access information easily. In-room technology, such as smart controls for lighting and climate, enhances convenience and personalization.

Data-driven insights can help hoteliers proactively cater to guest needs, from replenishing amenities to suggesting personalized experiences during the stay. By seamlessly integrating technology at various touchpoints, hoteliers can offer a more convenient, engaging, and unforgettable guest experience, culminating in heightened guest satisfaction and retention.

The Experience and Retention Phase

Problems

Offline to Online - Too Much Data Overkill: Transitioning from offline to online platforms can result in an overload of data, making it challenging to effectively manage and utilize.

Under-Utilized Data: Hotels often fail to maximize the potential of collected data. This may stem from inadequate filtering and cleaning of data, insufficient personnel dedicated to data management, or a lack of recognition of its importance.

Lack of Guest Recognition for Repeated Guests: Repeated guests are often required to provide the same information repeatedly, undermining the sense of recognition and personalization.

Lack of One-Stop Solution: The need to use multiple websites for various bookings, rather than a single platform on the hotel's website, can be inconvenient for guests. Additionally, limited offerings in the form of "old school" booths within hotels can limit the options available for booking tours and experiences.

Causes

Personalization: Hoteliers may not fully grasp the value of the data they collect and fail to utilize it for personalization, despite its potential to impress and retain customers.

Management's Mindset (Continuous Cycle): The available technology for collecting and analyzing data is not effectively embraced due to a lack of understanding of the benefits. Management's mindset may not align with the value of data and personalization.

Lack of Partnership by Hotels: Collaboration opportunities with other businesses, such as tour operators or aggregators, may not be explored, limiting the seamless platform and experience that can be offered to guests.

What can Hoteliers do?

Invest in Data collection and analysis:

Mindset and Training on Data Importance: Provide training and education to staff on the significance of data collection and utilization, emphasizing how it can enhance guest experiences and ongoing loyalty.

Use a CRM Vendor (Technology): Invest in Customer Relationship Management (CRM) technology and vendor solutions to efficiently manage guest data, enabling personalized interactions after their stay encouraging re-visits.

Management Support (Top-Down Effect): Secure support and endorsement from upper management to foster a culture that values data and personalization as vital elements of the guest experience.

List Experiences on Brand Website: Include various unique experiences on the hotel's brand website, providing guests with a convenient one-stop platform for booking tours and activities before, during and after their stay before returning.

Consider Partnerships: Explore partnerships with tour operators and aggregators to expand the range of offerings available to guests, saving time and providing a seamless and enriched experience.

One Team Collaborating For The Right Roadmap

The whitepaper is a result of 40+ hoteliers, technology experts coming together for a workshop powered by RateGain and Singapore Institute of Technology with participation from Google helping hoteliers think of solutions needed for today's challenges



How can You Move Forward

The customer journey, both figuratively and in practice, serves as a concept for improving guest experiences and presents several opportunities for hoteliers respectively. Traversing through the four phases of this journey, the interconnectivity of the challenges, causes, and proposed solutions presented in this white paper raise several implications for the hospitality industry, which are as follows:

Prioritize capturing data over expensive software Technology and Data-Driven Insights: Generative AI has made access to AI much cheaper, helping in analyzing data and automating simple processes to engage and understand guests better.

These technological foundations are paramount for optimizing operations and delivering personalized experiences. Moreover, effective data utilization assumes a pivotal role in converting amassed data into actionable insights, subsequently enhancing decision-making processes, personalized offerings, and overall guest satisfaction.

Don't Overinvest in one channel: While a lot of digital marketing gurus will suggest the opposite, however, keep a tab by capturing feedback from guests to understand which channel are they coming from and have a basic presence built out and if possible connect your website to them, to drive direct bookings.

Invest in personalizing your digital experience: This investment, while not a lot, will yield good results for your properties, as it will allow personalization based on the channel they come from. A booking engine that can identify which channel they are coming from and change the content and images basis the same, will have a higher chance of driving conversions.

Look beyond hospitality Training and Mindset Shift: A transformation in mindset at all management levels is imperative. Recognizing the value of data, technology, and personalization is fundamental in maintaining a competitive edge. Training initiatives focused on the significance of data collection and utilization bridge the gap between potential and actual implementation, consequently enhancing guest recognition, satisfaction and importantly, long lasting loyalty.

Reduce number of screens: During the Booking Phase, the provision of one-stop solutions on hotel brand websites assumes paramount importance in simplifying the customer journey and elevating guest convenience. This approach, consolidating the booking process from room selection to experience reservation, holds the potential to significantly enhance conversion rates and guest loyalty.

Experiential Merchandising: The emphasis on experiential merchandising is particularly salient in the Experience & Retention phase. It is crucial for hoteliers to expand their offerings beyond providing accommodation and to evolve into destinations offering unique, memorable experiences. This strategic shift towards experiential travel plays a pivotal role in retaining guests and cultivating brand loyalty.

Globalization and Localization of Payment Methods: The endeavour of serving diverse global markets, each characterized by its distinct technological preferences and payment methods, presents a significant industry challenge. Adaptation to these diversities through the provision of alternative payment options and tailored marketing efforts unlocks new prospects and broadens the customer base.

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